Go for a Flask developer

A field guide for directing the AI on minivoip and reading what it writes. It skips syntax drills on purpose. Every idea points to a real file in this repo, so you can open it and check.

1. The one-minute version

Question	Flask world	Go world
What runs?	Python reads your `.py` files each time it starts	`go build` turns the code into **one file** (`bin/app`) that runs by itself
When do typos show up?	When that line runs (often in production)	At build time. If it builds, every name, type and argument matches
Web framework	Flask	**None needed.** The standard library (`net/http`) has routing, cookies, forms, static files
Templates	Jinja2 (`.html`, read at runtime)	**templ** (`.templ`, turned into Go code, checked at build time)
UI components	Your Jinja macros (shadcn-style)	**shadcn-templ**: the same idea, copied into `components/`
`pip install`	`pip install x`, `requirements.txt`	`go get x`, `go.mod` + `go.sum`
virtualenv	Needed per project	Not needed. Each project's `go.mod` pins its own versions
Dev mode	`flask run --debug`	`task dev`
Production server	gunicorn + several worker processes	**The app itself.** One process uses every CPU core
Container	Python image + your code + gunicorn	Copy one file into a tiny image

Why Go for minivoip: it holds thousands of open connections (phone apps waiting for a call, WebSockets) in one small process, ships as a single file, and catches the AI's mistakes at build time instead of in front of a customer.

When not to pick Go: quick data scripts, notebooks, machine learning, anything that lives on Python libraries. Python stays the better tool there.

2. Install and the toolbox

Go is already installed here (`go version` shows 1.27). On a new Arch/Omarchy machine: `sudo pacman -S go`; elsewhere, download it from go.dev/dl. Tools you install with `go install` land in `~/go/bin` (already on your PATH).

The `go` command is the whole toolbox. No pip, black, pytest or virtualenv to set up separately:

You want	Python	Go
Add a library	`pip install requests`	`go get github.com/coder/websocket@latest`
Clean up unused libraries	edit requirements.txt by hand	`go mod tidy`
Install a command-line tool	`pipx install x`	`go install x@version`, or a `tool` line in `go.mod` (this repo does that for `templ`)
Run the code	`python app.py`	`go run .`
Build	(nothing)	`go build -o bin/app .`
Tests	`pytest`	`go test ./...`
Format	black	`gofmt` (every Go file in the world looks the same; no style debates)
Lint	flake8	`go vet ./...`

`go.mod` = `requirements.txt` + `pyproject.toml`: the project's name (`module minivoip`), the Go version, and the libraries. Lines marked `// indirect` are libraries of libraries; ignore them. **`go.sum`** = the lock file (fingerprints of every download). Never edit it; commit it.

Go culture leans on the standard library and adds few libraries. minivoip's own code uses a handful: templ (pages), coder/websocket (call setup), modernc.org/sqlite (the database) and golang.org/x/crypto (bcrypt, for passwords). Everything else in `go.mod` is pulled in by those.

3. The five ideas that make Go code readable

You don't need to write these. You need to recognise them.

3.1 A folder is a package

Every folder is one module of code, and its name is how other code calls it. `store.Open(...)` means "the `Open` function in the `store/` folder". `main.go` is the special `main` package: the program starts at `func main()`.

3.2 Capital letter = public

`store.Open` starts with a capital, so other folders can use it. `s.migrate` starts lowercase, so it is private to `store/`. Python's `_private` convention is a rule in Go, enforced by the compiler.

3.3 Structs and methods instead of classes

A `struct` is a class with data only: no inheritance. Functions attach to it as methods:

```
type Server struct {          // web/web.go
    Store *store.Store
    Hub   *calls.Hub
    Dev   bool
}

func (s *Server) dashboard(w http.ResponseWriter, r *http.Request, u store.User) {
        ... }
//    ^ "s" is "self"
```

The `*` means "share this one, don't copy it". That's all you need to know about pointers to read the code.

3.4 Errors are return values, not exceptions

There is no `try/except`. A function that can fail returns the result **and** an error, and the caller checks it right away:

```
l, err := s.Store.LineByName(r.PathValue("line"))   // web/dashboard.go
if errors.Is(err, store.ErrNotFound) {
    http.NotFound(w, r)          // like abort(404)
    return
}
if err != nil {
    serverError(w, r, err)       // like abort(500), and logs it
    return
}
render(w, r, pages.Call(l))
```

`if err != nil { return ... }` is the most common line in Go. When you skim, skip those lines and the real story is what's left. **Smell to watch for:** an AI that throws errors away (`_ = something()` or no `err` check), except where a comment explains why.

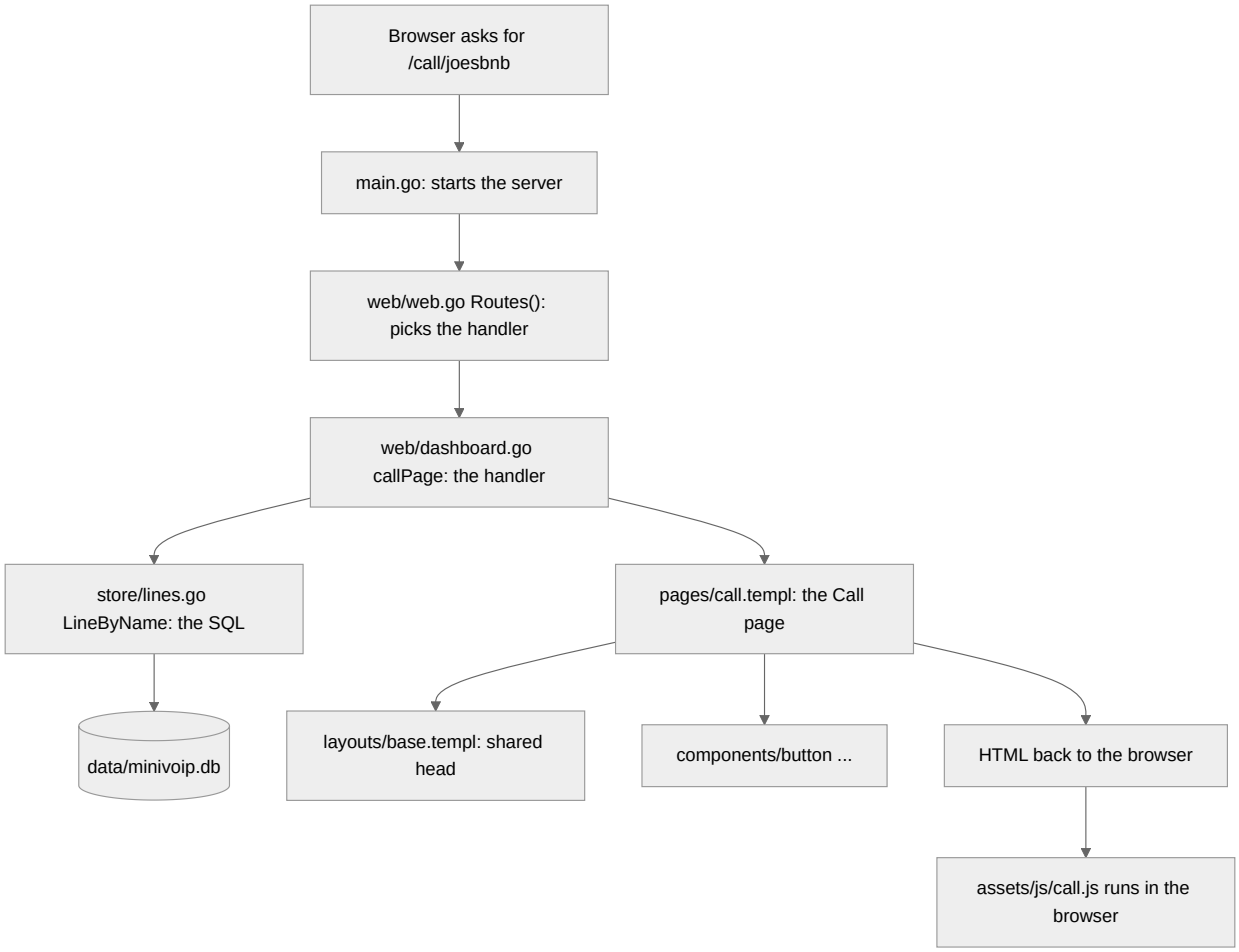
3.5 Interfaces are "anything that has this method"

Anything with a `ServeHTTP(w, r)` method counts as a web handler, without declaring it. That's why the call socket plugs straight into the router: `mux.Handle("GET /ws", s.Hub)`, because `calls.Hub` has a `ServeHTTP`.

Smaller things you will meet

- `defer x.Close()`: runs when the function ends, like `finally` or `with`.
- `go doSomething()`: runs it in the background at the same time (a "goroutine"). Cheap; you can have thousands.
- `sync.Mutex` (`mu.Lock()` / `mu.Unlock()`): one goroutine at a time touches this data. See `calls/hub.go`.
- **Zero values:** an unset field is `""`, `0`, `false` or `nil`, never "undefined". `pages.AccountForm{}` is an empty form, ready to show.
- `` `json:"line"` `` after a field: the name it gets in JSON. See `callData` in `pages/call.templ`.
- `import _ "modernc.org/sqlite"`: imported only so it plugs itself in (the SQLite driver).
- An unused import or variable stops the build. Annoying for humans, great for catching AI leftovers.
- `any` = "any type" (Python's untyped variable).

4. How a request flows (Flask vs Go)



Routes

```
# Flask
@app.route("/call/<line>")
def call_page(line):
    ...
```

```go
// Go: web/web.go, all routes in one list
mux.HandleFunc("GET /call/{line}", s.callPage)

// web/dashboard.go: the handler
func (s *Server) callPage(w http.ResponseWriter, r *http.Request) {
    name := r.PathValue("line")
    ...
}
```

`w` is where you write the answer, `r` is the request. Every handler has this shape.

The Flask-to-Go phrasebook

Flask	Go (this repo)
`@app.route("/x", methods=["POST"])`	`mux.HandleFunc("POST /x", s.handler)`
`request.form["email"]`	`r.FormValue("email")`
`request.args.get("next")`	`r.URL.Query().Get("next")`
`<line>` in the URL	`r.PathValue("line")`
`render_template("x.html", a=1)`	`render(w, r, pages.X(1))`
`redirect(url_for("dashboard"))`	`http.Redirect(w, r, "/dashboard", http.StatusSeeOther)`
`abort(404)`	`http.NotFound(w, r); return`
`@login_required`	`s.auth(s.dashboard)` wraps the handler (`web/web.go`)
`current_user`	the `u store.User` the auth wrapper passes in
`g` / request context	`r.Context()`
`app.config` / `os.environ`	`os.Getenv("MINIVOIP_DB")` in `main.go`
`static/` folder	`assets/`, built into the binary (`assets/assets.go`, `//go:embed`)
Flask-SocketIO / flask-sock	`calls/hub.go` with `coder/websocket`, no extra server needed

5. Templates: templ vs Jinja

The big shift: **a templ template is a function.** It has named, typed inputs, and the build fails if you pass the wrong thing. Jinja takes a loose bag of variables and fails at runtime (or prints nothing) when one is misspelled.

Passing variables

```python
# Flask
return render_template("dashboard.html", email=u.email, line=l, call_url=url)
```

```go
// Go: web/dashboard.go
render(w, r, pages.Dashboard(u.Email, l, baseURL(r)+"/call/"+l.Name))
```

```
// pages/dashboard.templ: the "template" declares what it needs
templ Dashboard(email string, l lines.Line, callURL string) {
    ...
    <h1>{ l.Business }</h1>
}
```

Jinja to templ

Jinja	templ
`{{ name }}`	`{ name }` (escaped automatically, safe against injection)
`{% if x %}…{% endif %}`	`if x { … }`
`{% for o in options %}`	`for _, o := range l.Options { … }`
`{% extends "base.html" %}` + `{% block content %}`	`@layouts.Base("Title", "") { …page… }` and the layout prints `{ children... }`
`{% macro button() %}` / `{{ button(...) }}`	`templ brand() { … }` / `@brand()`
Your shadcn Jinja macros	`@button.Button(button.Props{...})` from `components/button/`
`href="{{ url }}"`	`href={ url }` (no quotes around the braces)

Jinja	templ
`{{ data | tojson }}`	`@templ.JSONScript("id", data)` or a Go struct with json tags

Look at `layouts/base.templ` (the shared `<head>`, like your `base.html`) and `pages/account.templ` (`accountShell` is a small layout, `formField` is a macro). You already know this pattern; it's your own component project with types added.

The generated files

Each `x.templ` produces an `x_templ.go` next to it. That's the machine version, like a `.pyc` file. **Never open or edit `*_templ.go`.** `task dev` regenerates them as you save.

Components

`components/` holds shadcn-templ components (button, card, dialog, input, sidebar, table…). They're copied in, so they're our code to change. Add more with `shadcn-templ add <name>`. Rule for the AI: reuse one of these before writing new HTML widgets.

6. SQLite

Flask habit	Go here
SQLAlchemy / `sqlite3`	`database/sql` (built into Go) + the `modernc.org/sqlite` driver
ORM models	Plain structs (`lines.Line`, `store.User`) filled from plain SQL
Flask-Migrate / Alembic	A numbered list of SQL scripts in `store/store.go` (`migrations`)
`db.session.commit()`	`tx.Commit()`

Where to look:

- **The tables:** the `migrations` list at the top of `store/store.go`. At startup, `Open` runs any migration the file hasn't had yet (it counts them with SQLite's `user_version`). Rule: never edit a shipped migration, add a new one.
- **The queries:** one file per topic, `store/accounts.go`, `store/lines.go`. Every function is "one thing the app needs", like `CreateLine` or `LineByName`. Handlers never write SQL; they call these.

- **The file:** `data/minivoip.db` (not in git). The `-wal` and `-shm` files next to it are normal SQLite working files; leave them.

A typical read, so you recognise the shape:

```
err := s.db.QueryRow("SELECT id, name, business FROM line WHERE name = ?", name).
    Scan(&id, &l.Name, &l.Business)    // copy the columns into variables, in order
```

The `?` placeholders keep it safe from SQL injection, same as in Python. Going further, a tool called **sqlc** writes these Go functions from plain `.sql` files. Not needed yet; worth considering if `store/` grows large.

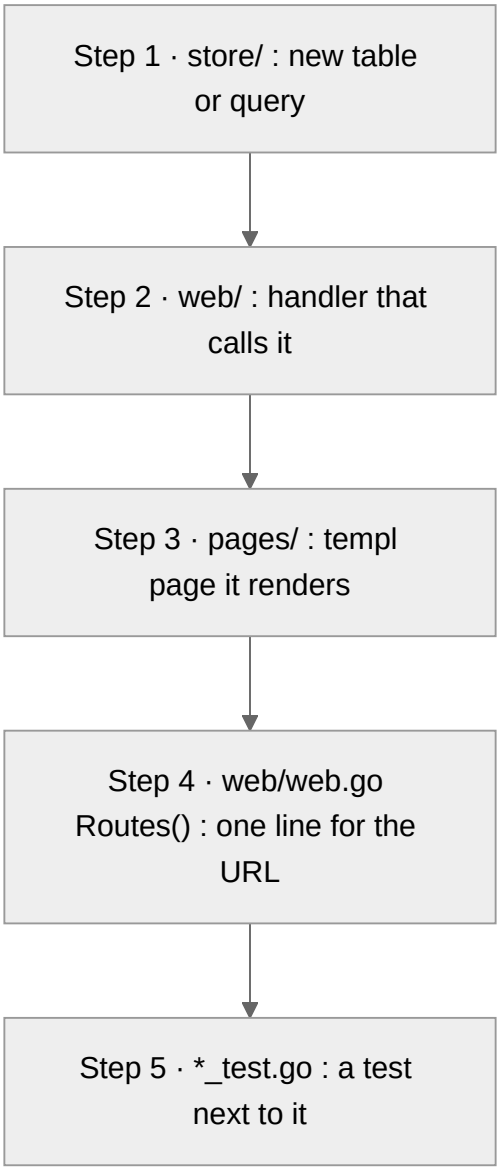
7. Which file do I open?

The map you'll use most.

You're wondering…	Open
What URLs exist, and which ones need a login?	`web/web.go` → `Routes()`
What happens on a given URL?	find its handler name in `Routes()`, then that function in `web/*.go`
What a page looks like	`pages/<page>.templ`
The shared `<head>`, fonts, scripts	`layouts/base.templ`
A button, input, dialog…	`components/<name>/`
The database tables	`store/store.go` (`migrations`), explained in `docs/data-dictionary.md`
A query	`store/accounts.go`, `store/lines.go`
What a line and its voice menu are	`lines/lines.go`
How a call is set up (ring, answer, hang up)	`calls/hub.go` (server side)
What runs in the visitor's browser / the owner's phone	`assets/js/call.js`, `assets/js/phone.js`
Port, database path, dev mode	`main.go`

You're wondering…	Open
Dev and build commands	`Taskfile.yml`
Libraries	`go.mod`
Container	`Dockerfile`
Tests	`*_test.go`, next to the code they test
The design and its decisions	`docs/architecture.md`, `docs/plan.md`
Never open	`*_templ.go`, `assets/css/output.css`, `assets/js/shadcn-templ-*.js`, `bin/` (all generated)

Adding a feature: the usual path



That's the sentence to give the AI: *"Put the SQL in* `store/`*, the handler in* `web/`*, the page in* `pages/`*, add the route in* `Routes()`*, and a test."* If a change doesn't fit this shape, ask why before accepting it.

8. Dev mode: the `flask run --debug` of Go

`task dev` (you run it in your own terminal) starts three watchers at once (see `Taskfile.yml`):

1. **templ**: when you save a `.templ` or `.go` file, it rebuilds and restarts the app (`go run`), then refreshes the browser. Open http://localhost:7331 (that address is the refreshing proxy; the real app is on 8090).
2. **tailwind**: rebuilds `output.css` when classes change.
3. **scripts-watch**: rebuilds the components' JavaScript bundle.

In dev mode the app also reads `assets/` from disk instead of from inside the binary, so CSS and JS changes show up immediately.

Where errors show up:

- **Build errors** (typo, wrong type): in the `task dev` terminal. The page doesn't reload. Go prints the `file:line` to open.
- **Runtime errors**: `log.Printf` lines in the same terminal (see `serverError` in `web/web.go`). If something crashes inside one request (a "panic"), Go logs it and keeps serving everyone else.
- **Browser-side** (`call.js`, `phone.js`): the browser's developer console, as before.

There's no in-browser debugger like Werkzeug's. In Go you debug mainly with **tests**: `go test ./...` runs all of them in a second or two, and `calls/hub_test.go` plays a whole call (ring, answer, hang up) without a browser. For breakpoints, the VS Code Go extension uses **Delve** (`dlv`), Go's debugger. Optional; not installed.

9. Production and containers

Why there's no gunicorn

Python runs one thing at a time per process (the GIL), so gunicorn starts several copies of the app to use several cores. Go doesn't have that limit: **one process** gives every request its own goroutine and spreads them over all cores by itself. No worker count to tune, no gevent for WebSockets. The binary *is* the production server.

One important consequence for minivoip: **run exactly one copy.** Two reasons:

- `calls/hub.go` keeps the ringing and live calls in memory. A second copy wouldn't know about them.
- SQLite is one file on one disk.

One Go process on a small server handles a lot of small businesses. When that stops being enough, it's an architecture change (shared state, another database), not a gunicorn setting. `docs/architecture.md` covers "growing later".

What's in the `Dockerfile`

It's a **multi-stage build**, the standard Go pattern:

1. A big image with Go, Tailwind and Task builds everything (`task build`).
2. Only `bin/app` is copied into a tiny Alpine image. Final size: tens of MB, versus hundreds for a Python image.

`CGO_ENABLED=0` makes the binary fully self-contained, which is why we picked the pure-Go SQLite driver. CSS, JS and logos are inside the binary (`//go:embed`), so nothing else needs copying.

Good practices for Phase 6 (not done yet)

Practice	Why	State today
Mount `data/` as a volume	the SQLite file must survive a container rebuild	not set up
Secrets as environment variables from `.env`	never baked into the image	`.env` is git-ignored
Run as a non-root user	limits damage if something breaks in	runs as root
Graceful shutdown	on stop, let calls and saves finish before exiting	`main.go` exits right away
Server timeouts (`http.Server`)	slow or stuck clients can't pile up	not set
A `/healthz` URL	lets Docker or the host check the app is alive	none
HTTPS in front (Caddy)	the app speaks plain HTTP; Caddy adds the certificate	how voip.dresdell.com works today

Go reads the container's CPU limit and sizes itself to it, so there's nothing to tune there.

Bonus: Go builds for another machine from yours. `GOOS=linux GOARCH=arm64 go build` produces a binary for an ARM server or a Raspberry Pi, no container needed.

10. Directing the AI: what good Go looks like

Ask for, and check for:

- **Standard library first.** "Can `net/http` / `database/sql` do this?" before any new library. Every new library needs your OK (project rule).
- **Thin handlers.** A handler reads the form, calls `store`, renders a page. SQL in a handler, or HTML built from strings in Go, is a smell.
- **Every error handled** or explained in a comment.
- **Small packages named for a thing** (`store`, `calls`, `lines`), never a junk drawer like `helpers` or `common`.
- **Tests next to the code**, run with `go test ./...`. Ask the AI to show you the run.
- **`go vet ./...` clean.**
- **No hidden global state.** Things get passed in, the way `main.go` builds the store and the hub, then hands them to `web.Server`.
- **Background work (`go ...`) has a clear end:** a timeout, a hang-up, a closed socket. A goroutine that never stops is Go's version of a memory leak.

Useful sentences:

- "Explain this change as: which URL, which handler, which store function, which page."
- "Add a migration; don't edit an existing one."
- "Reuse a component from `components/` before writing new HTML."
- "Show me `go test ./...` and `go vet ./...` output."

Reading a Go file in 30 seconds

1. The comment at the top says what the package is for (`// Package store keeps...`).
2. The `import` block tells you what it depends on: `minivoip/...` is our code, the rest is outside.
3. The `type ... struct` lines are its nouns.
4. Capitalised functions are what the rest of the app uses. Read those first.
5. Skip `if err ≠ nil` blocks on the first pass.

Good first reads, in this order: `main.go` → `web/web.go` → `pages/account.templ` → `store/store.go` → `calls/hub.go`.

11. Best practices you didn't ask about

Things experienced Go developers do without thinking. Each one has a short "why", and where minivoip stands today (checked 2026-10-21).

Go's own philosophy (the "Go proverbs")

- **Clear is better than clever.** Boring, obvious code is the goal. If you can't follow a change, ask the AI to make it plainer, not to explain the trick.
- **A little copying is better than a little dependency.** Ten copied lines beat a new library.
- **Errors are values.** Handle them where they happen, and add context on the way up.
- **Don't communicate by sharing memory; share memory by communicating.** Prefer passing messages between goroutines over many of them touching the same data. When they must share, protect the data with a mutex (`calls/hub.go` does).
- **Make the zero value useful.** A struct should work, or at least not crash, when nothing is filled in.

Errors

- **Wrap errors with context:** `fmt.Errorf("migration %d: %w", i+1, err)` (from `store/store.go`). The log then reads like a trail: `database: migration 2: no such table`. The `%w` keeps the original error inside.
- **Named errors for cases the caller must handle:** `store.ErrNotFound`, `store.ErrEmailTaken`, checked with `errors.Is`. This replaces Python's custom exception classes. ✅ done in this repo.
- **`panic` is for bugs, never for normal failures** like "user not found". Don't let the AI use it as `raise`.
- **Users see a kind sentence; the log gets the details.** `serverError` in `web/web.go` does exactly this. ✅

Testing

- **Table-driven tests:** one list of cases (input, expected) and one loop that checks them all. It's the standard Go test shape; ask for it when a function has many cases (like line-name rules in `lines/`).
- **Test the web layer without a browser:** the standard `net/http/httptest` package fakes a request and records the answer. ⚠️ `web/` has no tests yet; sign up, log in and "not logged in → redirect" are the first to add.

- **Run the race detector:** `go test -race ./...` finds two goroutines touching the same data at once, the nastiest kind of bug in a call server. ✅ passes today. Make it the normal way to run tests.
- **Tests use a throwaway database:** `t.TempDir()` in `store/store_test.go`. Never the real `data/` file. ✅
- **Coverage:** `go test -cover ./...` shows what share of the code the tests run.

Concurrency (the part Go is famous for, and the easiest to get wrong)

- **Every goroutine needs a way to end:** a timeout, a closed socket, a cancelled `context`. Otherwise they pile up silently.
- **Pass `context.Context` as the first argument** of anything slow (database, network). When the visitor closes the page, the context is cancelled and the work stops. Handlers get one from `r.Context()`.
- **Put a timeout on everything that goes out to the network.** `calls/hub.go` gives each send 5 seconds. ✅
- **Keep mutex-protected sections short**, and never wait on the network while holding the lock.

Code shape

- **Accept interfaces, return structs.** Define an interface where it's *used*, and only when there are two real implementations (or a test needs a fake). The AI tends to invent interfaces "for later": push back.
- **No package-level mutable globals.** Build things in `main.go` and pass them in. ✅ this repo does.
- **Names:** short in small places (`r`, `w`, `err`, `l`), descriptive for exported things. Don't repeat the package name: `store.Open`, not `store.OpenStore`.
- **Doc comments** start with the name: `// LineByName returns a line and its menu, or ErrNotFound.` They feed `go doc` and editor tooltips. ✅
- **`internal/` folder**: code under it can't be imported by other projects. Only matters if you ever publish a library; not needed for minivoip.
- **Generics exist** (since Go 1.18) but are rarely needed in a web app. If the AI reaches for them, ask why.

Database (SQLite)

- **One `*sql.DB` for the whole app.** It's a connection pool, not one connection. Open it once in `main.go`. ✅

- **Always** `defer rows.Close()` after a `Query`, and check `rows.Err()` at the end. ✅
- **Transactions:** `defer tx.Rollback()` right after `Begin`, `tx.Commit()` at the end. If anything returns early, the rollback cleans up. ✅ (`store/lines.go`)
- **WAL mode + busy timeout** so reads and writes don't block each other. ✅ (set in `store.Open`)
- **Backups.** ⚠️ Not set up. The SQLite file *is* the business. Before real customers: a nightly `sqlite3 data/minivoip.db "VACUUM INTO 'backup.db'"`, or **Litestream**, which streams changes to cheap storage continuously. Put this on the Phase 6 list.

Security

- **templ escapes everything by default.** Only `templ.Raw(...)` bypasses it; treat any use as a red flag to review.
- **Passwords with bcrypt** ✅, **session cookies** `HttpOnly`, `SameSite=Lax`, `Secure` behind HTTPS ✅, **forms from other sites refused** (`sameSite` in `web/web.go`) ✅.
- **Limit login attempts** (slow down repeated wrong passwords). ⚠️ not yet.
- **`govulncheck ./...`**: Go's official tool lists known security holes in the libraries *your code actually calls*. Not installed yet; run it before each release (`go install golang.org/x/vuln/cmd/govulncheck@latest`).

Tooling worth adding

Tool	What it does	Status
`gofmt`	formats code; your editor runs it on save	built in ✅
`go vet ./...`	catches suspicious code	clean today ✅
`staticcheck`	the most respected extra checker: dead code, misuse of the standard library	not installed
`golangci-lint`	runs many checkers at once; most teams use it in CI	not installed
`govulncheck`	known security holes in libraries	not installed
`pprof`	built-in profiler: where CPU and memory go. Measure before optimising	available when needed

(Adding any of these is a new build step, so it's your call per project rules.)

Logging and running in production

- **Structured logs with `log/slog`** (standard library): `slog.Info("call answered", "line", name)`. You get `key=value` or JSON lines you can search, instead of free text. The repo uses plain `log.Printf` today; switch when adding production logging.
- **Read config once at startup and fail fast:** if a required setting is missing, refuse to start with a clear message. ✅ (`main.go` stops if the database won't open.)
- **Stamp the version into the binary** (`go build -ldflags "-X main.version=..."`) and log it at startup, so you always know which build is running.
- **Keep Go up to date.** Go promises that old code keeps building on new versions, so upgrading is cheap and brings speed and security fixes. Two releases a year (February, August).

Housekeeping

- **`go mod tidy` before each commit that touches libraries.** It also fixes the labels: ⚠️ today `go.mod` marks `modernc.org/sqlite` and `golang.org/x/crypto` as `// indirect` although our code uses them directly. Harmless, but tidy fixes it.
- **Commit `go.sum`, and the generated `*_templ.go` files** (this repo does both), so a fresh checkout builds with `go build` alone.
- **Small commits, one idea each.** Go diffs are easy to review when each one tells one story.